STREAMER SCHOOL

2-Day Curriculum · Student Handout

Mac Brown Fly Fish · Fly Fishing Guide School · Bryson City, NC

14 Sessions	**~9 hrs** On-water time	**6** Core pillars	**2** Full days

Fly Design · Color Theory · Line Density Systems · Retrieval Vocabulary · Water Reading · Applied Hunting

> *"The real magic comes from matching colors to water type and weather conditions. You can have the most sophisticated fly in the box and still blank if the color doesn't fit the conditions. Color is the door you knock on first."*

macbrownflyfish.com · flyfishingguideschool.com

Quick reference

FLY CATEGORIES — SIX TYPES AND THEIR BEHAVIOR

Jigger	Dumbbell or tungsten eyes. Heavy, sinks fast. Vertical bounce on pause. Near-bottom cold-water tool.
Swimmer	Conehead or no weight. Fast, continuous retrieve. Materials shed water and dart. Clear, cold conditions.
Diver	Deer hair or foam head. Buoyant, dives on strip, surfaces on pause. Creates direction change and turbulence.
Walker	Wedge head (Drunk & Disorderly style). Erratic side-to-side on strip. Reaction-strike trigger.
Classic swing	Marabou/rabbit strip. Fished on the swing like a wet fly. Materials pulse with current.
Articulated	Hinged two-section body. Rear moves independently of head — most lifelike action on direction change.

COLOR MATCHING — CONDITIONS TO COLOR LOGIC

Clear water + bright sun	Natural tones: olive, white, tan, brown — fish inspect closely; sparse flash only
Clear water + overcast	UV materials, subtle flash: pearl, light chartreuse, soft bi-color
Stained / off-color	High contrast: black, chartreuse, purple, fire orange — silhouette over shade
Turbid / dirty water	Loudest possible: chartreuse, yellow, hot orange — lateral line + maximum visibility
Low light / dawn / dusk	Dark silhouettes: black, dark olive — hold contrast against sky
Post-storm / rising water	Bright with rattle: chartreuse + orange, or all-black — larger profile, push water
Rotation rule	Natural first → stained: step louder every 20 min with no contact → shift one step per condition change

LINE DENSITY — WHAT EACH DOES TO THE FLY

Floating	Maximum fly action — swimmer darts freely on pause. Best for shallow water, banks, active fish.
Intermediate (1–2 IPS)	Subtle depth, minimal surface drag — clear water, slow pools, stealthy presentations.
Sink tip 10–15 ft (Type 3)	Runs and pools to 6 ft — maintains floating running line for cast ease.
Sink tip (Type 5–6)	Deep runs, high water, cold tailwaters — sustained depth in fast current.
Full sinking line	Entire retrieve stays at depth — lake fishing, deep tailwater pools, maximum depth.
Integrated shooting head	Dense short head + floating running line — best turnover for large, wind-resistant flies.
Line + fly interaction	Floating line → diver surfaces on pause; sink tip → diver held at depth. Same fly, different behavior.

RETRIEVAL VOCABULARY — EIGHT KEY RETRIEVES

Strip-strip-pause	Two pulls, pause — fly flutters like injured prey. Foundation of all streamer

	retrieves.
Jerk-strip (Galloup)	Rod jerk + line strip in rapid succession — erratic direction change on every beat. High-speed trigger.
Slow glide	Long slow strips, extended pause — cold, inactive, or pressured fish in deep pools.
Walk-the-dog	Lateral head movement on each strip — requires wedge-head fly. Side-to-side direction change.
Jigging retrieve	Rod-tip vertical oscillation — dumbbell-eye fly bounces near bottom. Near-bottom cold-water method.
Dead drift to animate	Let fly drift naturally, then 1-2 sharp strips — surprise attack on stationary predator.
Follower protocol	Speed up → change direction → sudden stop. Force the decision within 3 casts.
Short strike response	Pause immediately after missed hit, then rip — fish that missed will return.

THE DECISION SEQUENCE — HOW TO CHOOSE ON THE WATER

1	**Read conditions**	What is the water clarity? What is the light? What is the weather doing?
2	**Select color**	Apply physics: clear+sun=natural; stained=contrast; dirty=loud; low light=dark silhouette.
3	**Choose line**	Match density to depth needed and fly action required — not just depth.
4	**Pick fly category**	Jigger for cold/deep; swimmer for fast/clear; diver for active/mid-depth; walker for reaction strikes.
5	**Select retrieve**	Start with strip-strip-pause. Adjust cadence, speed, and direction based on fish response.
6	**Cover water**	Cast angle → retrieve → step → repeat. First cast to every lie is the highest-probability presentation.

Day 1 — Fly design, color theory & line systems

7:30 – 8:30 am

Welcome — the evolution of streamer fishing & what's changed

PHILOSOPHY

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

- Understand why streamer fishing has transformed more dramatically than any other fly discipline in the past decade
- Appreciate the role of new materials, articulation, and swimming physics in modern fly design
- Distinguish the three functional categories: jigging streamers, swimming streamers, and walking/diving streamers
- Establish color matching as the real competitive edge — more impactful than any single technique

KEY CONCEPTS

◆ The streamer revolution: Galloup, Lynch, Game Changer, articulated systems — 30 years of acceleration ◆ Marabou, rabbit strip, schlappen, UV materials, rubber legs — each does a specific job ◆ Articulation: independent body movement at the hinge — more lifelike than any single-hook fly ◆ Rattle flies: water displacement through sound + lateral line — effective in stained/turbid water ◆ Divers: deer hair, foam, or wedge-head patterns that dive on the strip and surface on the pause ◆ Three categories: jiggers (vertical bounce), swimmers (fast continuous retrieve), walkers (direction changes) ◆ Lateral line of the trout: senses water displacement and vibration — materials matter in low visibility ◆ Color is the final decision but the most impactful for conditions

ACTIVITIES

- Fly board: 12 patterns sorted by category — students identify the swimming mechanism of each
- Bathtub/tank demo: observe each fly type in clear water — watch how materials pulse, breathe, and push water
- Discussion: what streamer fishing looked like 20 years ago vs. today — materials, hooks, articulation

> **MB** *"The evolution is real. Better materials, better hooks, better articulation — but the real magic comes from matching colors to water type and weather conditions. You can have the most sophisticated fly in the box and still blank if the color doesn't fit the conditions."*

8:30 – 10:15 am

Fly anatomy deep dive — materials, profiles, swimmers, divers & rattles

FLY DESIGN

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

- Understand what each material contributes: marabou breathes, rabbit strips undulate, schlappen pushes water, UV reflects
- Distinguish when to choose a bulky push-water pattern vs. a sparse fast-swimmer
- Know the role of head design: conehead sinks, deer hair dives, dumbbell eyes jig, wedge head walks
- Apply rattle and diver mechanics to specific low-visibility conditions

KEY CONCEPTS

◆ Marabou: breathing movement in slow water, adds bulk — can overload in fast water ◆ Rabbit strip: continuous undulation even at rest — most lifelike material in still or slow water ◆ Schlappen / hackle: push water and create turbulence — lateral line trigger in stained conditions ◆ UV and flash: enhance, don't dominate — flash attracts attention; UV penetrates deep water and overcast light ◆ Sparse materials: fast swimmers shed water and dart — clear, cold, pressured conditions ◆ Dense materials: push water and vibrate — stained, warm, or low-light conditions ◆ Conehead: sinks fast, jigging action on pause — deep cold water tool ◆ Deer hair head (muddler/diver): buoyant, dives on strip, surfaces on pause — creates direction change ◆ Dumbbell eyes: heavy, inverted hook, jigging bounce — near-bottom presentations ◆ Wedge head: erratic side-to-side walk on strip — reaction-strike trigger ◆ Rattle chambers: vibration signature — replaces visual attraction in turbid or night conditions ◆ Articulation: rear section moves independently of head — triggers during direction changes

ACTIVITIES

- Material function exercise: match each material to its primary purpose and best conditions
- Strip test in clear water: observe conehead, deer hair, and dumbbell-eye behavior on the pause
- Profile comparison: sparse vs. dense version of same pattern — when does each earn its place?

> ✓ **Checkpoint:** Each student correctly categorizes 10 patterns by swimming behavior and can explain the head design choice for two different water conditions.

10:15 – 10:30 am	*Break & walk to water*

10:30 am – 12:00 pm	**Color theory — matching water clarity, weather & light conditions**	COLOR

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

- Understand the physics of light penetration and color absorption underwater — why red vanishes at depth
- Apply the contrast-over-color rule for stained and turbid water
- Match fly color to water clarity, weather condition, light angle, and time of day
- Build a systematic color-rotation protocol when conditions change

KEY CONCEPTS

◆ Light physics: colors vanish with depth — red first, then orange, yellow; blues and greens last ◆ Clear water + bright sun: natural tones — olive, white, tan, brown — fish inspect closely ◆ Clear water + overcast: UV materials and subtle flash — pearl, light chartreuse, bi-color ◆ Stained / off-color water: high contrast — black, chartreuse, purple, fire orange ◆ Turbid / dirty water: loudest possible — chartreuse, yellow, hot orange — maximum visibility ◆ Bright conditions: silver and gold flash attract; on overcast, they become invisible ◆ Dark or overcast: UV reflectance — purples and blacks hold profile in dim light ◆ Low light / dawn / dusk: dark silhouettes — hold contrast against the sky ◆ Two-tone countershading: dark back, light belly — matches baitfish profile from every angle ◆ Rotation protocol: natural first → stained: step louder every 20 min with no contact

ACTIVITIES

- Color decision table: 8 condition scenarios — students assign fly color and justify with physics logic
- River walk: instructor calls conditions — students pull correct color from box before instructor reveals
- Side-by-side drift: fish natural and chartreuse in same run — observe visibility difference at distance

> **MB** *"Color matching to conditions is the real magic of streamer fishing. I've watched anglers make dozens of perfect retrieves with the wrong color and blank, then switch to the right one and get hit on the first cast. The retrieve matters — but color is the door you knock on first."*

> ✓ **Checkpoint:** Each student correctly assigns color logic to 6 of 8 condition scenarios and can articulate the physics reason behind each choice.

12:00 – 12:45 pm	*Lunch on the river*

12:45 – 2:30 pm	**Line density systems — floating to full sink & when each serves**	LINES

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

- Understand the full spectrum of streamer line densities and what each controls
- Match line density to water depth, current speed, fly design, and retrieval technique
- Know when a floating line is actually the superior choice over a sink tip
- Understand how line density affects fly action — not just depth

KEY CONCEPTS

◆ Floating line: maximum fly action — fly swims freely; best for shallow riffles, banks, and darting swimmers ◆ Intermediate (1–2 IPS): subtle depth, minimal surface drag — clear water, slow pools ◆ Sink tip Type 3 (5–7 IPS, 10–15 ft): runs and pools to 6 ft — floating running line for casting ease ◆ Full sinking line Type 3–6: sustained depth on entire retrieve — deep pools, tailwaters, high water ◆ Integrated shooting heads: dense short head + floating running line — best turnover for large flies ◆ Triple density (I/S3/S5): different sink rates through head — fly swings at consistent depth ◆ Grain weight: heavier grain for larger flies and wind; lighter for small patterns and accuracy ◆ Line density affects action: floating line lets swimmer dart on pause; sink tip holds swimmer at depth ◆ Leader length: 6–9 ft on floating for stealthy presentations; 2–4 ft on sink tips for depth control

ACTIVITIES

- Line comparison on the water: same fly on floating, intermediate, and sink tip — student calls the behavioral difference
- Water-to-line matching: 5 water types — students select line density and leader length combination
- Diver fly observation: buoyant head on floating vs. sink tip — observe how behavior changes completely

MB *"Line choice isn't just about depth — it's about how the fly behaves. A buoyant diver on a floating line does something completely different than the same fly on a sink tip. The myriad of density choices exist because each one creates a different swim behavior from the same fly."*

✓ **Checkpoint:** Each student correctly selects line density for 4 of 5 water scenarios and explains how the chosen line affects fly behavior — not just depth.

2:30 – 4:00 pm

Day 1 debrief, first water work & the approach cast

APPLIED

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

- Apply fly selection, color logic, and line choice on the water for the first time
- Practice the approach cast: angle, mend, and initial position before the retrieve begins
- Understand why the cast angle controls the retrieval arc — not just where the fly lands
- Begin developing retrieval intuition through observation and repetition

KEY CONCEPTS

◆ Cast angle determines retrieval arc: across-and-down gives full swing; up-and-across gives longer drift before retrieve ◆ Rod tip position at start: down in water = tight contact; high = more slack and fly action ◆ Mend before retrieve: upstream mend gives fly time to sink and positions the arc ◆ Bang-the-banks: cast tight to structure, retrieve fast — big trout ambush prey from cover ◆ Dead drift to retrieve transition: let fly sink on natural drift, then animate — surprises inactive fish ◆ Cross-current angle: fly faces multiple lies as it swings through the arc

ACTIVITIES

- Cast angle drill: same spot, 3 different angles — observe how retrieval arc changes for each
- Bank-targeting: land fly within 18 inches of bank — 10 repetitions, instructor grades accuracy
- Fly watch: observe own fly in first 5 seconds of the drift before the retrieve begins

✓ **Checkpoint:** Each student lands 7 of 10 casts within 18 inches of the bank and demonstrates three different cast angles with deliberate purpose.

Day 2 — Retrieval mastery, presentation & reading water

7:30 – 8:45 am

Retrieval mechanics — speed, direction change & the pause as a weapon

RETRIEVAL

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

- Master the full retrieval vocabulary: strip-strip-pause, jerk-strip, slow-glide, walk-the-dog, jigging, dead drift-to-animate
- Understand why change of direction triggers more strikes than speed alone
- Know when the pause is the weapon vs. when constant motion is required
- Convert followers into eaters through systematic retrieval adjustment

KEY CONCEPTS

◆ Strip-strip-pause: foundation — two pulls, then pause — fly flutters like injured prey ◆ Jerk-strip (Galloup): rod jerk + line strip in rapid succession — erratic, high-speed, direction change ◆ Slow glide: long slow strips with extended pause — cold water, inactive fish, deep pools ◆ Walk-the-dog: lateral head movement on each strip — wedge-head fly — side-to-side direction change ◆ Jigging retrieve: rod tip oscillates vertically — dumbbell-eye fly bounces near bottom ◆ Dead drift to animate: let fly sink, then 1-2 sharp strips — surprise attack on stationary predator ◆ Change of direction: most consistent strike trigger — fly changes horizontal direction = prey escaping ◆ Pause duration: longer in cold water; shorter in warm active conditions ◆ Followers: speed up, change direction, sudden stop — force the decision within 3 casts ◆ Speed as trigger: faster-fleeing prey = less inspection time — instinct overrides caution ◆ Never Mach 5: trout are not stripers — erratic always beats pure speed

ACTIVITIES

- Retrieval vocabulary drill: 6 retrieves, 5 casts each — student executes each distinctly and names it
- Follower conversion: instructor calls 'follower' — student executes direction change within 2 casts
- Observe your fly: stand in flat water and watch fly behavior on each retrieve type — learn the fish's-eye view

MB

> *"The retrieve is where the game is really won or lost. You can have the right fly and the right color, but if you're giving it the same retrieve on every cast you're leaving fish behind. Change of direction and speed variation are the two most consistent strike triggers I know."*

✓ **Checkpoint:** Each student demonstrates 5 distinct retrieves with clearly different cadence and executes a follower-conversion sequence on command.

8:45 – 10:15 am

Reading water for streamers — lies, ambush points & hunting vs. holding

WATER READING

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

- Distinguish active hunting positions from passive holding lies for streamer presentation
- Target undercut banks, wood, depth transitions, seam edges, and current breaks as ambush architecture
- Understand how a predatory trout's lane of vision differs from a feeding trout's
- Apply systematic water coverage — cast, arc, step, repeat — to grid a run efficiently

KEY CONCEPTS

◆ Predator lies: structure + depth transition + adjacent current — the ambush architecture ◆ Undercut banks: biggest trout live here — fly within inches; 5 hard strips then move on ◆ Wood: logs and root wads create current breaks — presentation within 6 inches or forget it ◆ Depth transitions: where shallow meets deep — trout patrol this edge; fly should cross the transition ◆ Seam edges: cast into fast water, retrieve across the seam into the slow side ◆ Large pool pockets: trout holding mid-depth — intermediate or sink tip, slow glide ◆ Hunting vs. holding: active fish intercept; passive fish need fly in their face ◆ Dark holding lies: deep shadows, overhanging cover — dark flies, approach quietly ◆ First cast rule: first presentation to any new lie = highest-probability cast — make it count

ACTIVITIES

- Lie identification walk: instructor calls lie types, students call approach angle and retrieve for each
- Systematic coverage: student grids 50-yard run top to bottom — instructor confirms no lie skipped
- First-cast focus: one cast to each new lie — resist the urge to repeat immediately

✓ **Checkpoint:** Each student correctly identifies lie type and names the retrieve approach for 5 different water features, then grids a run top-to-bottom without skipping structure.

10:15 – 10:30 am	*Break*

10:30 am – 12:00 pm	**Swing, dead drift & the transition retrieve — passive streamer methods**	PASSIVE

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

- Execute the classic downstream swing with a streamer and control arc speed through mending
- Apply the dead drift streamer technique for passive, inactive fish
- Master the transition: dead drift into animate — the surprise-attack approach
- Understand when passive methods outperform active stripping

KEY CONCEPTS

◆ Downstream swing: quartering cast, upstream mend to sink, line comes tight, fly swings — emergence at depth ◆ Control the arc: upstream mend slows the swing; leading rod tip speeds it — fish the entire arc ◆ The hang: fly hesitates at end of swing — hold 5 seconds — most strikes happen here ◆ Dead drift streamer: fly drifts naturally with no retrieve — marabou and rabbit pulse with current alone ◆ Transition retrieve: 2-5 seconds dead drift, then 1-2 sharp strips — prey awakening = strongest trigger ◆ Eddy presentation: cast into eddy, let fly sink, twitch gently — do not strip — marabou does the work ◆ Mending the swing: mend into structure to guide fly within inches of the lie ◆ When passive wins: cold water, inactive fish, heavily pressured water, low-light conditions

ACTIVITIES

- Swing arc control: mend to slow, lead rod to speed — student fishes same cast three ways and observes arc
- Hang drill: hold fly at full downstream tension for 5-count on every cast — break the habit of early recast
- Dead drift watch: let marabou streamer dead drift 10 feet in calm water — observe material movement

✓ **Checkpoint:** Each student demonstrates three distinct swing speeds via mending, and holds the hang for a full 5-count before recasting.

12:00 – 12:45 pm	*Lunch*

12:45 – 2:30 pm	**Applied streamer session — independent hunting**	APPLIED

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

- Self-select fly, color, line, and retrieve for conditions without instructor input
- Hunt water systematically — grid, cover, move — without camping on unproductive lies
- Convert followers and short strikes through retrieval adjustment
- Adapt in real time to changing light, weather, and water conditions

KEY CONCEPTS

◆ Decision sequence: read conditions → select color → choose line → pick fly category → select retrieve → execute ◆ 5-cast rule: if a lie hasn't produced in 5 well-placed presentations, move on ◆ Short strike response: pause immediately after hit, then rip — fish that missed will return ◆ Follower protocol: speed up, change direction, sudden stop — force the decision within 3 casts ◆ Adapting to light change: cloud cover → step louder in color; sun returns → step back to natural

ACTIVITIES

- Independent 40-minute water hunt: self-directed decisions — fly, color, line, retrieve
- Mid-session check: student explains current fly, color, line, retrieve choice — instructor validates or redirects
- Peer observation rotation: one hunts, one observes retrieve consistency, coverage discipline, adaptation

MB *"The real magic is when all the pieces connect — right color for the light, right line for the depth, right retrieve for the fish's mood. That's not something you learn from a chart. That's something you learn from hunting water with intention."*

✓ **Checkpoint:** Each student makes and verbalizes three condition-based adjustments, covers the assigned water without skipping structure, and explains every gear choice with logic.

2:30 – 4:00 pm **Final debrief, written assessment & path forward** REVIEW

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

- Synthesize the two-day arc: fly design → color → line → retrieval → presentation → water reading
- Receive individual written feedback
- Identify one retrieval priority and one color/condition priority
- Build a personal 30-day streamer practice plan

ACTIVITIES

- Written instructor assessment: fly classification, color logic, line selection, retrieval vocabulary, presentation execution, water reading
- Individual feedback: one strength, one priority, one habit to build on every outing
- Recommended resources: Kelly Galloup Modern Streamers for Trophy Trout, Troutbitten streamer series
- 30-day plan: one retrieval focus per outing, color journal — log conditions and color choice each session

✓ **Checkpoint:** Completed written assessment returned to each student. Instructor retains copy for program records.